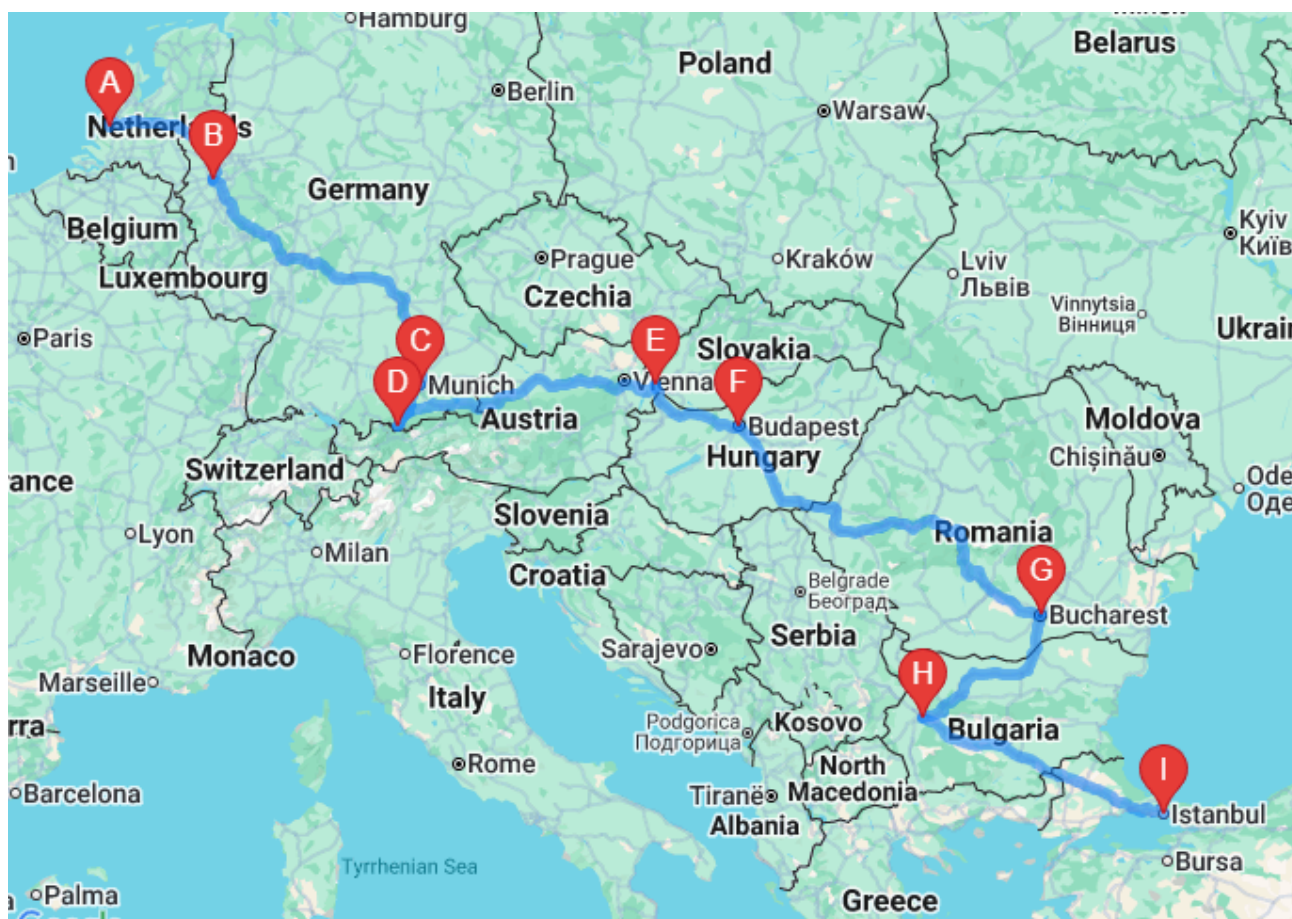


2026 Itinerary

Stop	Destination	Arrival Date	Departure Date	Nights Stayed
1	Delft (Netherlands)	Fri 17 Jul	Fri 17 Jul	0
2	Düsseldorf (Germany)	Fri 17 Jul	Sat 18 Jul	1
3	Munich (Germany)	Sat 18 Jul	Tue 21 Jul	3
4	Garmisch-Partenkirchen (day trip from Munich)	Mon 20 Jul	Mon 20 Jul	0
5	Bratislava (Slovakia)	Tue 21 Jul	Thu 23 Jul	2
6	Budapest (Hungary)	Thu 23 Jul	Fri 24 Jul (night train)	1
7	Bucharest (Romania)	Sat 25 Jul (arrival)	Mon 27 Jul	2
8	Sofia (Bulgaria)	Mon 27 Jul	Wed 29 Jul (night train)	2
9	Istanbul (Turkey)	Thu 30 Jul (arrival)	Sun 2 Aug	3

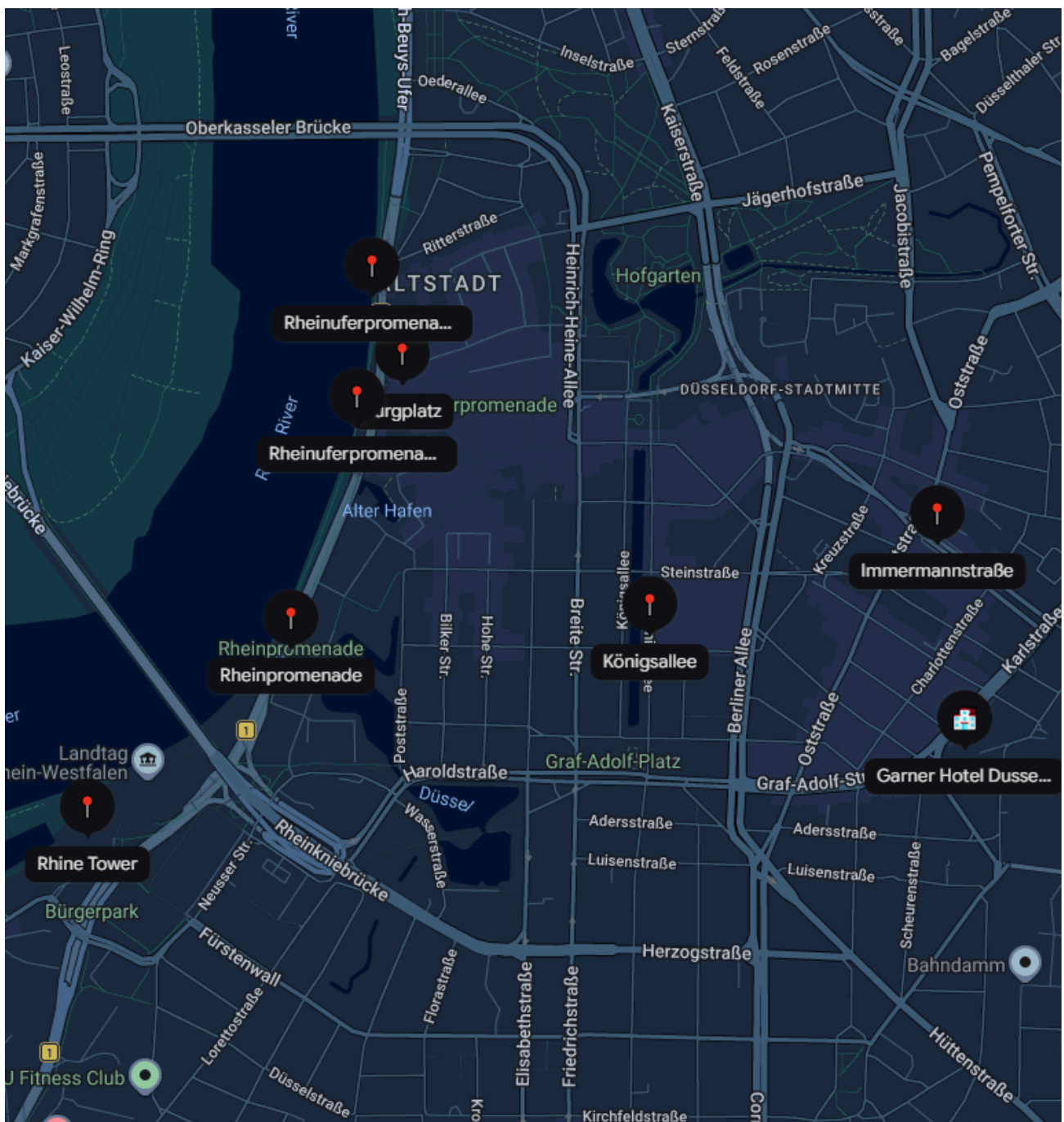


Düsseldorf (Germany) | Fri 17 Jul – Sat 18 Jul

Delft → Duesseldorf Hbf 09:38 - 12:45

- **Duration:** 3h 7m (1 transfer)
- **Leg 1:** 09:38 Delft → 10:48 Utrecht Centraal (IC 3535, Open seating)

- **Transfer:** 14 mins at Utrecht Centraal
- **Leg 2:** 11:02 Utrecht Centraal → 12:45 Duesseldorf Hbf (ICE 123, **Reservation required**)



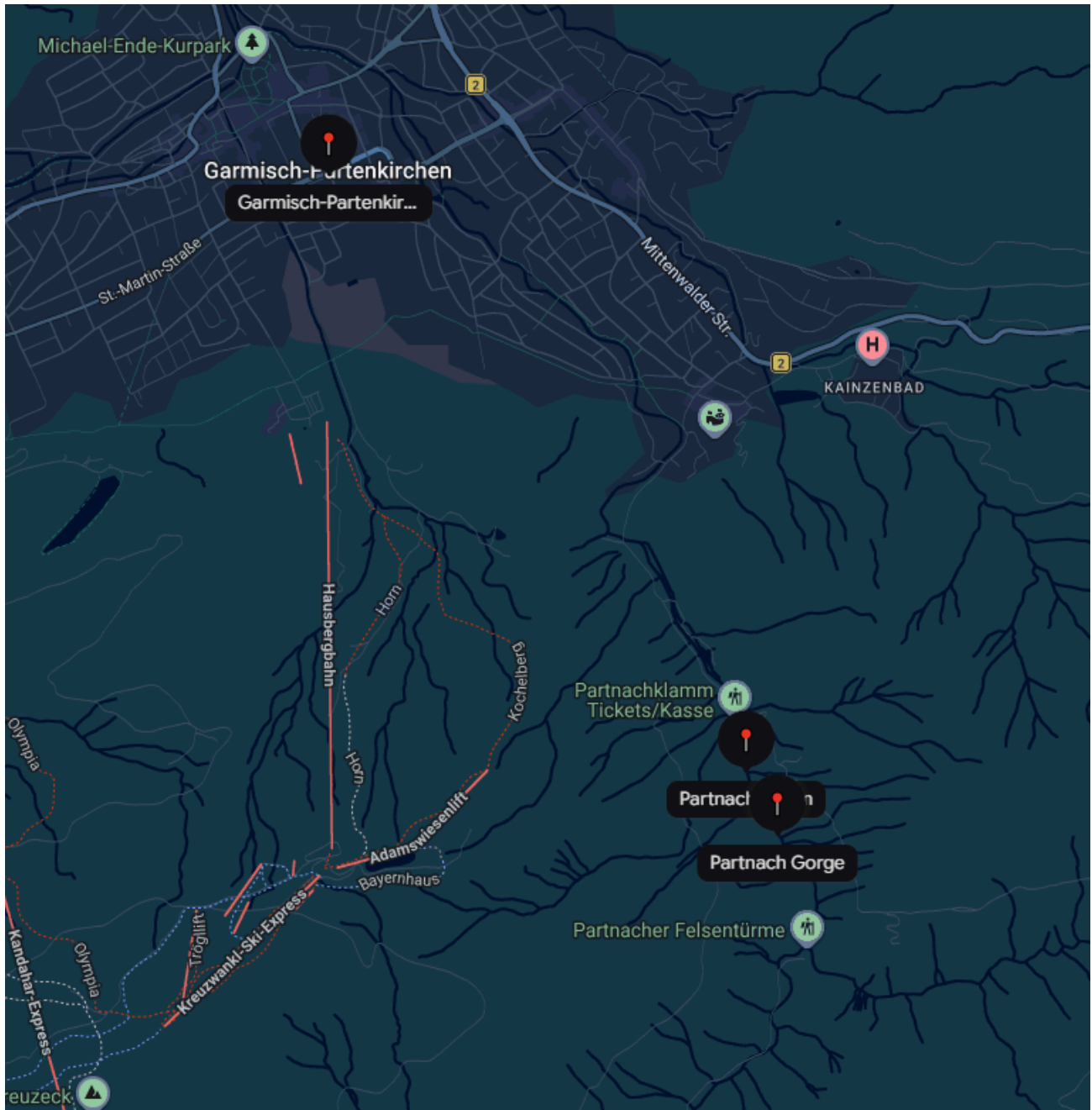
- **Hotel:** Garner Hotel Düsseldorf - Main Station by IHG.
- **Stop 1 – Little Tokyo:** Ramen, sushi, and bakeries along Immermannstraße (right by the station).
- **Stop 2 – Königsallee ("Kö"):** Scenic luxury canal walk shaded by massive chestnut trees.
- **Stop 3 – Altstadt & Burgplatz:** Cobblestone old town streets leading to the historic castle tower square.
- **Stop 4 – Rheinuferpromenade:** Car-free waterfront pedestrian stroll to watch the cargo ships pass.
- **Stop 5 – Rhine Tower (Rheinturm):** High-speed elevator up 240 meters for 360-degree skyline views.

DE Munich (Germany) | Sat 18 Jul – Tue 21 Jul

Duesseldorf Hbf → Muenchen Hbf 10:22 - 15:12

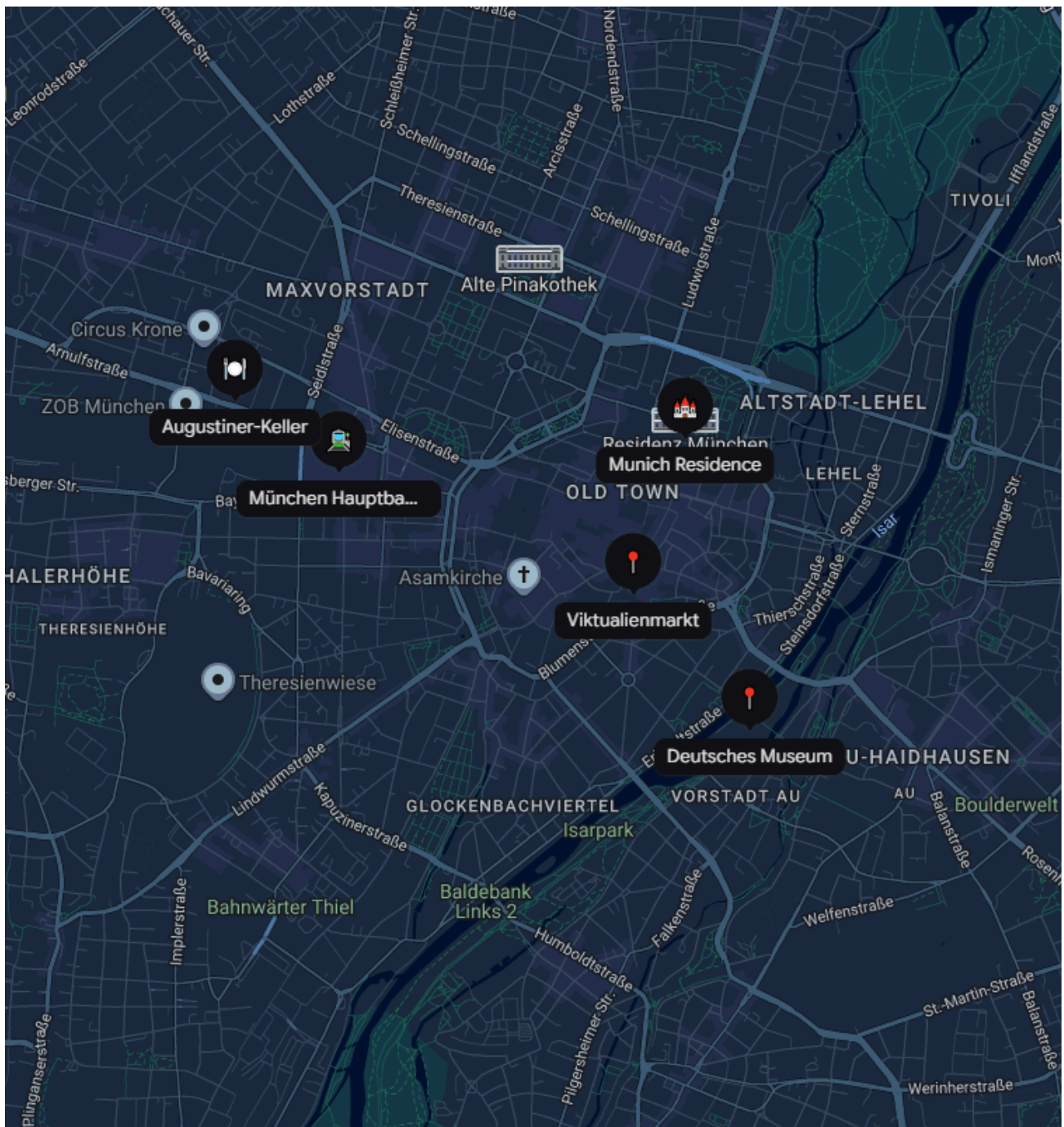
- **Duration:** 4h 53m (direct)
- **Train:** ICE 623 (Operated by NS International)
- **Hotel:** H+ Muenchen.

☀️ ****Option A: Clear Skies – Alpine Adventure (Garmisch-Partenkirchen)****



- **08:00** – Catch a direct regional train from München Hbf to Garmisch-Partenkirchen (~1h 20m).
- **Morning** – Board the historic **Bayerische Zugspitzbahn** cogwheel train and cable car to the summit of the **Zugspitze** (2962 m) for views across four countries.
- **Early Afternoon** – Take the **Cable Car Zugspitze** down to **Eibsee**, a crystal-clear, emerald-green alpine lake at the mountain's base. Stroll the flat lakeside path.
- **Late Afternoon** – Ride back down to town. Walk through the roaring waterfalls of **Partnach Gorge**, or view traditional painted houses (*Lüftlmalerei*) in Partenkirchen.
- ***Ticket Tip:** Use a **Bayern Ticket** or **Guten Tag Ticket** for cheap, flexible family regional travel.*

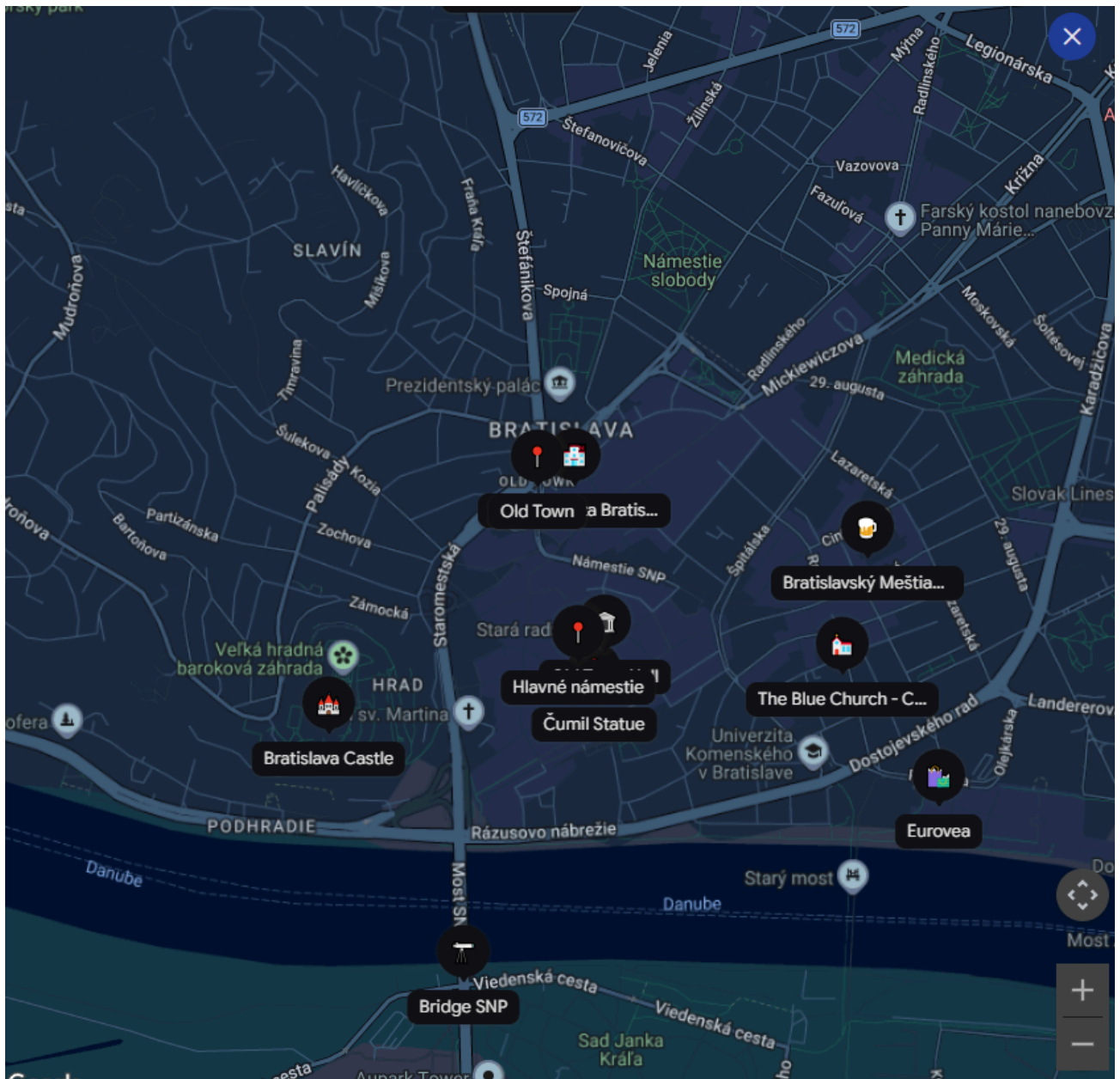
☁/☔ **Option B: Rainy Day – Munich City Culture**



- **Morning** – Traditional Bavarian breakfast (Pretzels and *Weißwurst*) at **Viktualienmarkt**, followed by an indoor tour of the grand **Residenz** palace.
- **Afternoon** – Explore the **Deutsches Museum** on the Isar River—the world's largest science and tech museum, featuring massive interactive halls on flight, space, and physics.
- **Evening** – Escape the damp weather with a warm, hearty dinner in a historic hall like **Augustiner-Keller**.

sk Bratislava (Slovakia) | Tue 21 Jul – Thu 23 Jul

Muenchen Hbf Gl.5-10 → Bratislava Hlavna Stanica 10:21 - 16:10



- **Hotel:** Crowne Plaza BRATISLAVA by IHG
- **Duration:** 5h 49m (1 transfer)
- **Leg 1:** 10:21 Muenchen Hbf Gl.5-10 → 14:47 Wien Hbf (EC 1213, Reservation optional)
- **Transfer:** 27 mins at Wien Hbf
- **Leg 2:** 15:14 Wien Hbf → 16:10 Bratislava Hlavna Stanica (RE 2522, Open seating)

****Day 1: Tuesday, 21 Jul – Arrival & Quirky Statues****

- **Afternoon** – Arrive at Bratislava Main Station from Munich via Interrail. Transit to your hotel.
- **16:00** – Walk the pedestrian **Old Town (Staré Mesto)** and hunt for the famous bronze "**Man at Work**" (**Čumil**) statue.
- **18:00** – Explore the Old Town Hall at the historic **Main Square**.
- **19:30** – Local Slovak dumplings (*Bryndzové Halušky*) for dinner at *Bratislavský Meštiansky Pivovar*.

****Day 2: Wednesday, 22 Jul – Castles & UFO Views****

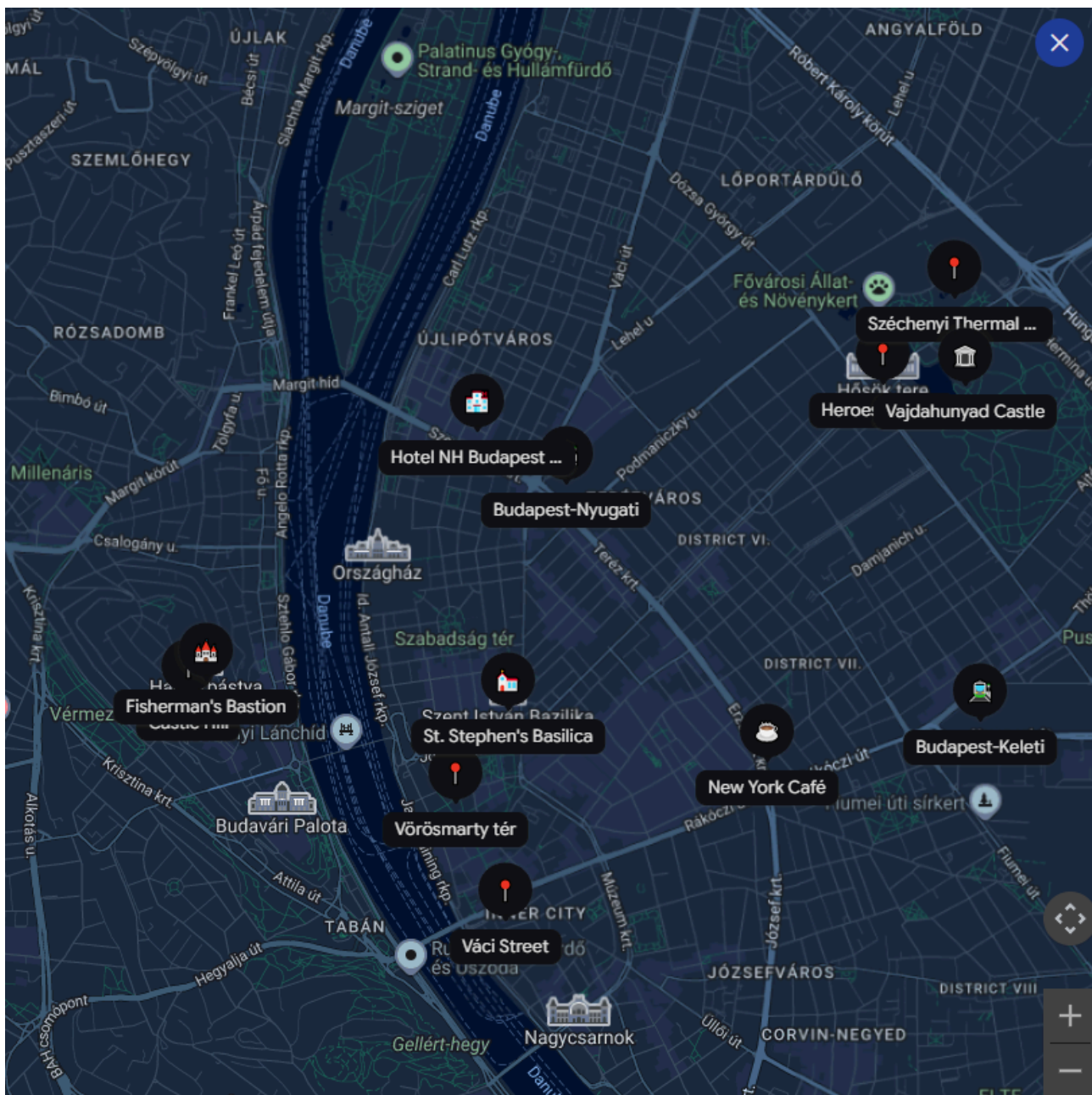
- **09:30** – Walk up the hill to **Bratislava Castle** for panoramic views overlooking the Danube.

- **13:00** – Relaxed lunch at a quiet old-town terrace café.
- **15:00** – Visit the whimsical, completely pastel-blue **St. Elizabeth's Church (The Blue Church)**.
- **17:30** – Ride the elevator up to the **"UFO" Observation Deck** atop the bridge for sunset views.
- **19:30** – Relaxing dinner along the Eurovea riverside promenade.

hu Budapest (Hungary) | Thu 23 Jul – Fri 24 Jul (Night Train)

Bratislava Hlavna Stanica → Budapest-Nyugati 10:05 - 12:28

- **Duration:** 2h 23m (direct)
- **Train:** RJ 273 METROPOLITAN (Railjet, Operated by České dráhy, a.s.)



Day 1: Thursday, 23 Jul – Arrival & Illuminated River

- **12:28** – Arrive at **Budapest-Nyugati** from Bratislava. Take the metro to check into **NH Budapest City**.
- **14:30** – Stroll through the lively pedestrian zones of **Vorosmarty Square** and **Váci utca**.
- **17:00** – Tour the magnificent grand interior of **St. Stephen's Basilica**.

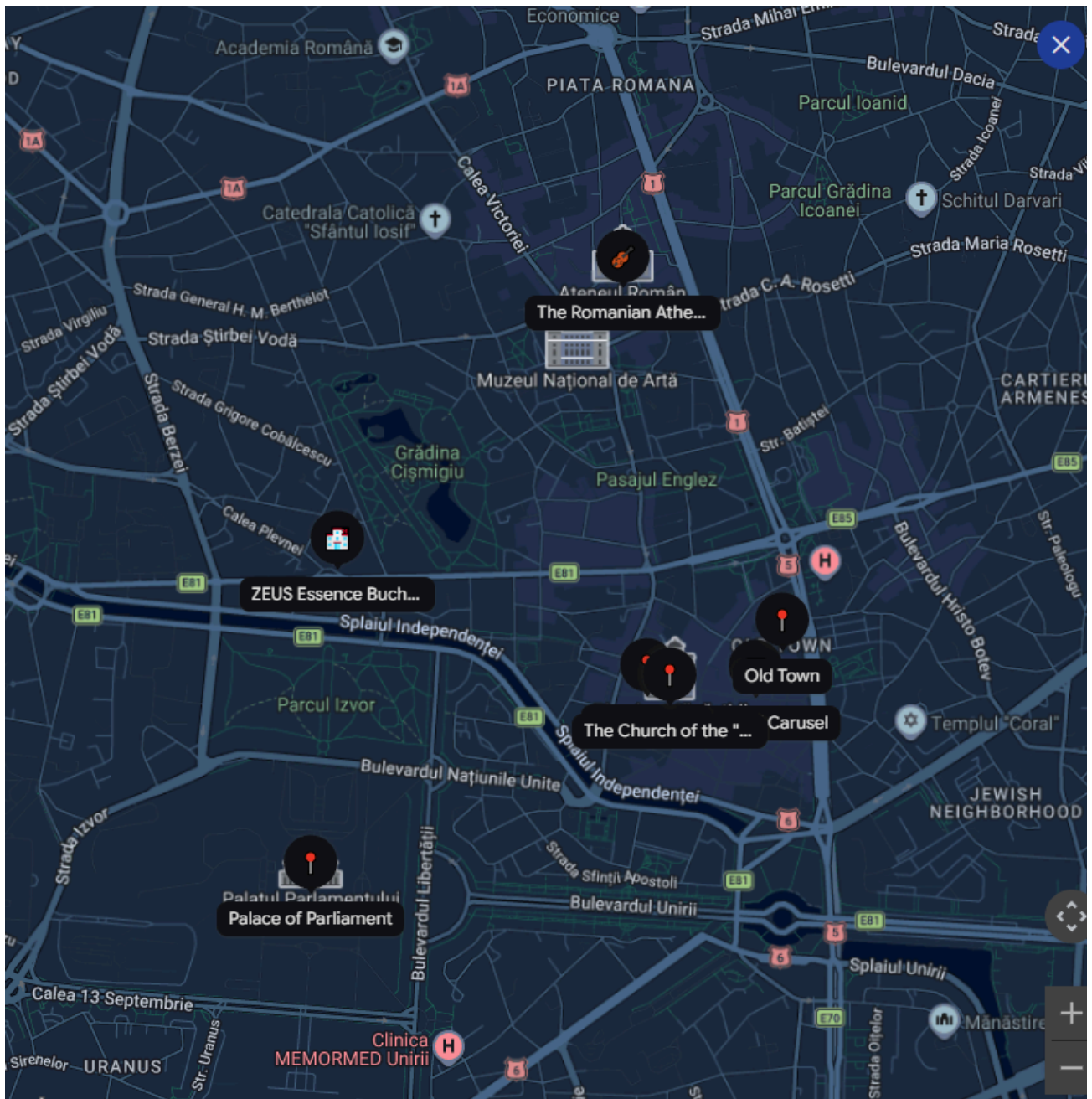
- **19:30 – Danube Sightseeing Cruise:** Watch the Hungarian Parliament and Buda Castle illuminate brilliantly from the water.
- **21:00** – Casual dinner in the historic **Jewish Quarter**.

****Day 2: Friday, 24 Jul – Castle District, Thermal Baths & Departure****

- **09:00** – Checkout and leave your suitcases in the ibis Styles secure **luggage room**.
 - **09:30** – Head up **Buda Castle Hill** to explore the fairy-tale towers of **Fisherman’ s Bastion** and **Matthias Church**.
 - **12:30** – Quick transit across Pest to **Heroes’ Square** and **Vajdahunyad Castle**.
 - **13:30 – Széchenyi Thermal Bath:** Enjoy a highly relaxing 2.5-hour soak in the outdoor thermal pools before your long train ride.
 - **16:30** – Late dinner or coffee/cake inside the stunning, historic **New York Café** right next to your hotel.
 - **17:45** – Collect your bags from the hotel lobby.
 - **18:15** – Walk 10 minutes or take the metro 1 stop straight to **Keleti Station**.
 - **19:10** – Board the **"Ister" Night Train** to Bucharest (private 3-bed family sleeper cabin).
-

ro Bucharest | Sat 25 Jul – Mon 27 Jul

Train: Budapest-Keleti → Bucureşti Nord **Arrival:** Sat 25 Jul, 10:37



Hotel: Zeus Essence Bucharest Venezia

Saturday 25 Jul

- Check in / lunch
- Palace of the Parliament (book ahead, bring passports)
- Stavropoleos Monastery
- Cărturești Carusel
- Old Town Bucharest
- Evening walk: Calea Victoriei & Romanian Athenaeum
- Dinner: Caru' cu bere

Sunday 26 Jul

- Dimitrie Gusti National Village Museum
- King Michael I Park
- Afternoon at Therme Bucharest

- Dinner in the city center
- Piața Unirii Fountains (if running)

Top Priorities

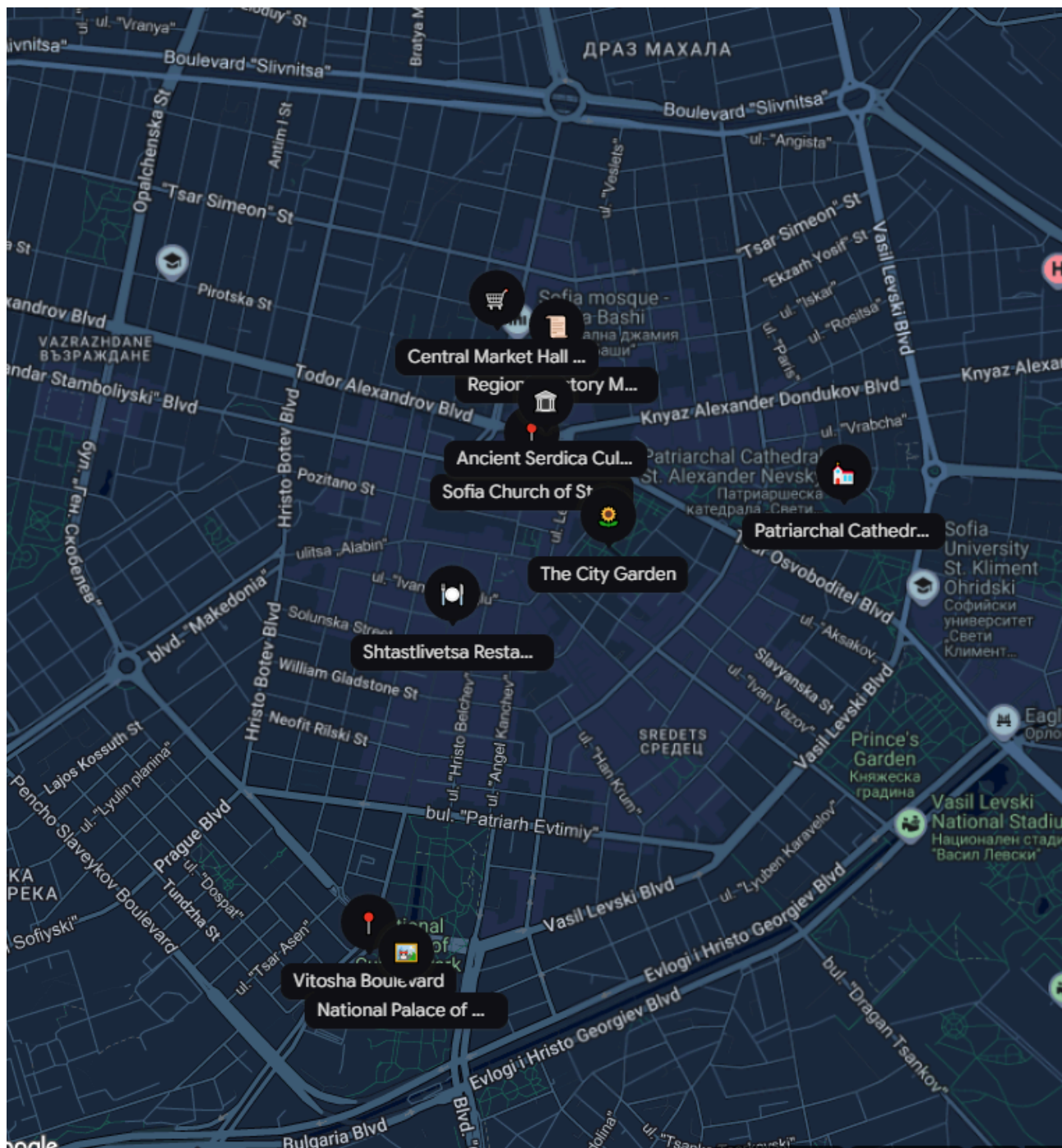
1. Palace of the Parliament
2. Old Town Bucharest
3. Calea Victoriei
4. Dimitrie Gusti National Village Museum
5. Therme Bucharest

That's essentially the "Bucharest greatest hits" album: one giant communist palace, one charming old quarter, one elegant boulevard, one slice of Romanian history, and one afternoon of thermal pools engineered to keep children from staging a rebellion.

BG Sofia (Bulgaria) | Wed 27 Jul – Thu 29 Jul (Night Train)

Bucuresti Nord → Sofia 10:46 - 20:41

- **Duration:** 9h 55m (direct)
- **Train:** INT 461 International (Operated by Societatea Nationala de Transport Feroviar de Calatori)
- **Seating:** **Seat reservations required** (€6.00 for 2nd class)



****Mon, 27 Jul – Departure & Arrival****

- **10:46** – Board direct train (INT 461) at **București Nord**.
- **20:41** – Arrive at **Sofia Central Station** and take the metro to your hotel.
- **Evening** – Late dinner and a stroll down pedestrianized **Vitosha Boulevard**.

****Tue, 28 Jul – Old Sofia & Golden Domes****

- **Morning** – Visit the ancient **St. George Rotunda**, see the underground **Serdika Roman ruins**, and explore the **Regional History Museum** (former Central Baths).
- **Lunch** – Traditional Bulgarian dishes at *Shtastliveca Vitoshka*.
- **Afternoon** – Marvel at the gold-domed **St. Alexander Nevsky Cathedral** and relax in the **City Garden** by the National Theater.
- **Dinner** – Classic clay-pot dinner at a traditional tavern (*Mehana*).

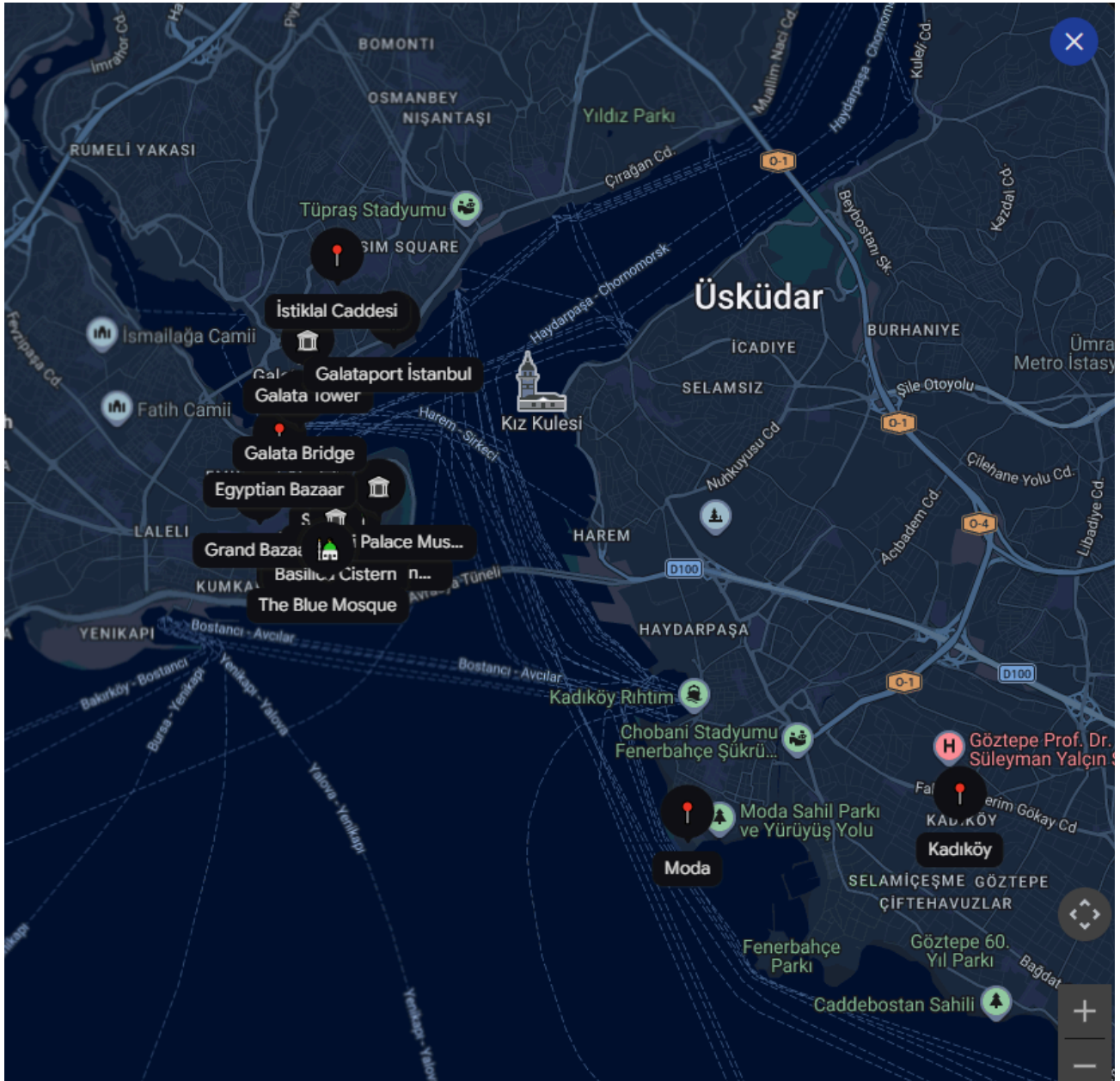
****Wed, 29 Jul – Parks, Markets & Night Train****

- **Morning** – Walk the wooded trails of **Borisova Gradina Park** and view the **National Palace of Culture (NDK)** plaza.
- **Afternoon** – Stock up on travel snacks (like *banitsa* and *lukanka*) at the **Central Market Hall (Halite)** and collect your bags.
- **Evening** – Head to the Central Station to board your international night train.

TR Istanbul (Turkey) | Thu 30 Jul – Sun 2 Aug

Sofia → Istanbul (Halkalı) 18:50 - 09:56

- **Duration:** 15h 6m (direct overnight train)



****Day 1: Thu, 30 Jul – Imperial Heart & Underground Wonders****

- **09:56** – Arrive at Istanbul Halkalı Station on the night train. Take the direct **Marmaray** commuter rail straight to the historic center (Sirkeci/Sultanahmet). Drop bags at your hotel.

- **13:30** – Stand inside the jaw-dropping **Hagia Sophia** and cross the main square to view the historic cascading domes of the **Blue Mosque**.
- **16:00** – Descend into the **Basilica Cistern**, an atmospheric 6th-century Roman reservoir featuring beautifully lit columns and mysterious Medusa head carvings.
- **19:30** – Dinner in Sultanahmet trying local *Sultanahmet Köftesi* (traditional grilled meatballs).

****Day 2: Fri, 31 Jul – Sultans, Grand Bazaars & Spices****

- **09:00** – Explore **Topkapı Palace**, the sprawling cliffside home of the Ottoman Sultans. Tour the beautiful maze of the *Harem* and the Imperial Treasury.
- **13:30** – Walk through the bustling historic tunnels of the **Grand Bazaar** and the neighboring **Spice Market** (perfect for picking up authentic Turkish Delight).
- **16:30** – Cross the **Galata Bridge** on foot to watch hundreds of local fishermen casting lines over the water.
- **18:30** – Take the elevator up the medieval stone **Galata Tower** for a 360° panoramic sunset view of the golden city.

****Day 3: Sat, 1 Aug – Intercontinental Ferry & Asian Side****

- **10:00** – Catch a public zig-zag **Bosphorus Ferry** from Eminönü pier. It's an incredibly relaxing, cheap boat ride that cruises between Europe and Asia past fortresses and palaces.
- **12:00** – Hop off on the **Asian Side (Kadıköy)**. Explore its vibrant local food markets and street art.
- **15:00** – Take a relaxed seaside stroll down the promenade in the trendy neighborhood of **Moda**.
- **18:30** – Ferry back to the European side to enjoy a final seaside dinner at the ultra-modern **Galataport** waterfront.

****Day 4: Sun, 2 Aug – Tram Ride & Flight to Beijing****

- **09:30** – Pack up and check out of your hotel. Stroll down pedestrian **Istiklal Avenue** to see the iconic vintage red tram.
- **11:15** – Early lunch or grab hot, fresh *Simit* (sesame bread rings) from a street cart. Collect your suitcases from the hotel.
- **12:00** – **DEPART FOR AIRPORT:** Take a pre-booked taxi/private shuttle or the direct **Havaist Airport Bus** from Sultanahmet straight to Istanbul Airport (IST).
- **13:00** – Arrive at the airport **2.5 hours early** to comfortably clear Istanbul's strict double-security screening for your **15:30 flight** back home to Beijing!

 **Luggage & Transit Tip:** Istanbul Airport (IST) is vast and requires a lot of walking inside the terminal. Booking a private airport shuttle from your hotel lobby at 12:00 is the most seamless, stress-free choice for a family traveling with international flight luggage.

Category 1: Train Passes & Seat Reservations (Interrail Extensions)

- **Delft → Düsseldorf (Fri 17 Jul):** ICE 123 Seat Reservation (Utrecht → Düsseldorf). Use [bahn.de](https://www.bahn.de) and select "Seat only". *Cost: €5.50 per seat.*
 - **Düsseldorf → Munich (Sat 18 Jul):** ICE 623 Seat Reservation. Use [bahn.de](https://www.bahn.de) and select "Seat only". *Cost: €5.50 per seat.*
 - **Munich → Garmisch-Partenkirchen Day Trip (Mon 20 Jul):** Regio-Ticket Werdenfels. Buy on the DB Navigator app. This out-of-pocket regional ticket allows Joey to travel entirely for free and saves an Interrail day! *Cost: ~€34 total for the family.*
 - **Munich → Bratislava (Tue 21 Jul):** EC 1213 Seat Reservation (Munich → Vienna). Use [oebb.at](https://www.oebb.at) and select "Seat only". *Cost: €3.00 per seat.*
 - **Bratislava → Budapest (Thu 23 Jul):** Point-to-Point Train Ticket. Buy via [zssk.sk](https://www.zssk.sk) or [jegy.mav.hu](https://www.jegy.mav.hu) for the EuroCity Metropolitan train to save your final Interrail pass day. *Cost: ~€30–€40 total.*
 - **Budapest → Bucharest Night Train (Fri 24 Jul):** Private 3-Bed Sleeper Cabin ("Triple") on the *Ister* Night Train. Book via [jegy.mav.hu](https://www.jegy.mav.hu), applying your Interrail pass number to pay only the cabin reservation supplement. *Cost: ~€84 total.*
 - **Bucharest → Sofia (Mon 27 Jul):** Mandatory Seat Reservation for the INT 461 International train. Book via the official Eurail/Interrail website's Self-Service portal. *Cost: €6.00 per seat.*
 - **Sofia → Istanbul Night Train (Wed 29 Jul):** Private 1st Class 2-Bed or 3-Bed Sleeper Reservation on the *Sofia-Istanbul Express*. Cannot be bought online. Secure it physically at Bucharest Nord station when you arrive on July 25th, or book ahead via a regional rail agency (like RILA travel). *Cost: ~€10–€15 per berth supplement.*
-

Category 2: Sights & Activities (High-Demand)

- **Budapest – Danube Sightseeing Cruise (Thu 23 Jul):** Evening cruise ticket. Book online via *Legenda Cruises* or similar to guarantee open-deck seating for the Parliament illumination.
- **Budapest – New York Café (Fri 24 Jul @ 16:30):** Table reservation. Book directly via newyorkcafe.hu to avoid a 45+ minute queue before your night train.
- **Bucharest – Palace of the Parliament (Sat 25 Jul):** Guided Tour Ticket. Guided entry is legally mandatory and caps fill up fast. Book 1–2 weeks ahead on their official site. (*Note: Must bring physical passports to enter*).
- **Bucharest – Therme Bucharest (Sun 26 Jul):** Timed entry ticket. Book directly from their official website to skip the brutal summer ticketing queue at the entrance.
- **Istanbul – Hagia Sophia (Thu 30 Jul):** Official Skip-the-Line Entry Ticket. Buy via the official Turkish Ministry of Tourism portal. Skip the ticketing queue entirely to enter the upper tourist gallery. Joey is 12, so he requires a standard ticket. *Cost: €25 per person.*
- **Istanbul – Basilica Cistern (Thu 30 Jul):** Timed Mobile Entry Ticket. Book online a few days ahead to sail right past the ticket window queues on the pavement. *Cost: 1,950 TL (€39) per person.*

To make this incredible rail expedition run completely seamlessly, here is the exact list of non-obvious gear, specific packing rules, and physical items you need to prepare before you leave Delft.

1. Mandatory Gear for the Night Trains

European night trains are an adventure, but the cabins do not function like hotel rooms. You must pack a small, dedicated **"Night Train Daypack"** for the family so you don't have to crack open your large suitcases in the cramped sleeper compartments:

- **A Power Strip / Multi-Plug Adapter:** Sleeper cabins (especially on the *Ister* to Bucharest and the *Sofia-Istanbul Express*) usually only have **one single plug socket** for the whole compartment. Bring a small extension cord or multi-USB block so all three of you can charge your phones and devices overnight.
 - **Flip-Flops / Slipper Shoes:** You will need these to comfortably walk down the corridor to the shared train toilets in the middle of the night without having to lace up your walking shoes.
 - **Wet Wipes & Dry Tissues:** Train bathrooms regularly run out of toilet paper and running water by 4:00 AM. Having wet wipes and pocket tissues handy is a lifesaver.
 - **A Power Bank:** Just in case the single socket in your cabin is broken or lacks power (which happens occasionally on older Balkan rolling stock).
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2. Strict Dressing Packing List for Therme Bucharest & Mosques

Two stops on your trip have incredibly strict, legally enforced clothing rules that will ruin your day if ignored.

For Therme Bucharest (Sun 26 Jul):

- **Clean Flip-Flops/Slippers:** You are **strictly forbidden** from walking inside the spa barefoot or in shoes you wore outside. You must pack a dedicated pair of clean flip-flops for each family member that you *only* put on inside the changing room.
- **Towels:** While you can rent towels there for a fee (~31 RON / €6), packing your own lightweight microfiber travel towels saves you money and checkout time.
- **Zone Age Limit Note:** Because Joey is 12, your family will spend your time in the **Galaxy Zone** (the massive family slide and wave pool area). The *Palm* and *Elysium* wellness zones are strictly restricted to guests aged 14 and above.

For the Istanbul Mosques (Thu 30 Jul):

- **Modest Clothes:** No shorts, short skirts, or sleeveless tank tops are allowed for adults or teens. Pack lightweight linen trousers or long jeans for yourself, your wife, and Joey for this day.
 - **A Headscarf:** Your wife must cover her hair completely to enter Hagia Sophia and the Blue Mosque. Pack a light, easily packable scarf in her daypack.
-

3. Physical Documents & Passport Copies

Because you are crossing multiple non-Schengen zones and taking land trains, do not rely entirely on your phones.

- **Physical Chinese Passports + Dutch Resident Cards:** Keep these together in a secure, RFID-blocking neck pouch or waist money belt. You will need them to cross into Romania, Bulgaria, and Türkiye, and you **must present physical passports** to enter the Palace of the Parliament in Bucharest.
 - **Printed Copies of Train Pass/Reservations:** Print out physical paper copies of your Interrail pass cover sheet, your *Ister* sleeper reservation, and your Istanbul train reservation. If your phone battery dies during a 15-hour overnight transit, a physical paper backup keeps train conductors happy.
-

4. Mobile Apps to Download Right Now

Download these apps while you are still in Delft and set up your ABN AMRO card profiles in them ahead of time:

- **DB Navigator (Germany):** For tracking platform changes in Düsseldorf and activating your Garmisch regional pass.
- **BudapestGO (Hungary):** To purchase your 24-hour family group transit pass digitally.
- **Yellow Taxi / Taxime (Bulgaria):** The safest, official apps to call metered taxis in Sofia to avoid tourist taxi scams at the central station.
- **BiTaksi (Türkiye):** Istanbul's primary taxi-hailing app, which routes metered rides directly to your phone.